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GEN. UPENDRA DWIVEDI
Chief of the Army Staff

whether Indians can patrol, say, at Finger 8 of Pangong. Before 2020, the Indian army sent soldiers from its base at the Dhan Singh Thapa Post near Finger 3 for patrol up to Finger 8. There is also the question of the degree of de-induction of military assets deployed by both sides.

Military planners are also wary of how to rebuild ‘trust’. “That will happen once we can see and reassure each other that we are not encroaching into buffer zones that are created.... Patrolling gives you that advantage and, as we restore trust, other stages will follow soon,” says army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi.

Gen. Dwivedi’s concerns are echoed by Lt Gen. Rakesh Sharma (retd), former commander of the Leh-based 14 Corps. “With these measures, can we really rebuild trust among the soldiers deployed at the LAC? I don’t think it will be easy.” A way forward, he believes, is to commence discussions with China on the delimitation and delineation process of the LAC. “Till we persist with ‘perceptions of LAC’ there are bound to be problems,” says Lt Gen. Sharma.

Significantly, the Chinese PLA has recently sought patrolling rights in two places in Arunachal Pradesh which are under Indian control—Yangtse, northeast of Tawang, where Indian and Chinese soldiers clashed in October 2022, and a valley along the Subansiri river. It has yet to be seen if the patrolling arrangements in Eastern Ladakh were agreed upon in exchange for giving the Chinese the right to patrol in the far east.■

AVIATION

TO GROUND THE FLYING HOAXES

By Avishek G. Dastidar

In response to a surge of false bomb threats—over 100 in recent days—that have hit India’s aviation sector hard, the government is poised to implement some of the most stringent penalties in the industry’s history. Under the proposed legislation, individuals making fraudulent claims about explosives aboard aircraft will pay for their mischief with sentences ranging from five years to life imprisonment, along with substantial fines and permanent placement on no-fly lists.

The crisis comes at a particularly inopportune moment—during India’s bustling festive season—prompting heightened security measures across the nation’s airports. “We’re changing the Aircraft Security Rules to put offenders on the no-fly list as a deterrent,” explains civil aviation minister Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu. The ministry is also pursuing amendments to the Suppression of Unlawful Acts against Safety of Civil Aviation (SUSCA) Act of 1982, expanding its scope to address threats made from beyond airport perimeters.

While the existing legislation prescribes life imprisonment for violence aboard aircraft or at airports—including communication of false threats—it contains a critical loophole: threats made from outside the airport or when the plane is not airborne aren’t



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Civil Aviation Minister



GROUNDED Passengers board another plane after their Vistara flight to Germany landed in Turkiye due to a bomb threat, Sept. 7

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